

How to read a political science article

POU11011 · Michaelmas Term 2026

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New document — Claude’s proposal. You asked for something on the web and as a PDF; this is it. The underlying questions are lifted from your own Russian Politics syllabus (itself adapted from Timothy Frye), pitched down to a first-year who has never opened a journal article. Nothing in it binds anyone — it is advice, not policy. The worked example is flagged separately below.

You will be assigned things this term that do not read like anything you have read before. A journal article is not a textbook chapter and not a news story. It is an argument, and it is written for other researchers, which is why it often feels harder than it needs to be.

This is how to get what you need out of one in about forty minutes.

The test

You have done a reading when you can, without looking at it:

- **state the argument** in two or three sentences;
- **say what evidence** it rests on;
- **name one thing wrong with it**, or one thing it does not explain.

If you cannot do those three, you have not done the reading — however long you spent on it. Reading the abstract, the introduction and the conclusion is not doing the reading, and it is obvious in a tutorial.

Three kinds of reading, three different jobs

	What it is for	How to read it
Textbook chapter (Heywood & Laing)	The map: vocabulary, the main positions, the shape of the debate	Read it first, and read it properly. It is the easiest thing you will read all week

	What it is for	How to read it
Journal article or book chapter	One person's argument, and their attempt to prove it	Use the order below. This is where the work is
News and blogs	The case you will argue about	Read normally, but note what a concept from the module would say about it

Read an article in this order

Not front to back. Nobody reads them front to back.

1. **Abstract** (1 min). What is the question and what do they claim to have found?
2. **Introduction** (5 min). The question again, why it matters, and — usually in the last paragraph — a map of the whole article. Slow down here.
3. **Conclusion** (5 min). What they think they showed. Reading this early makes the middle far easier.
4. **Now the middle** (20 min). You are looking for the argument and the evidence, not for every detail. Read the first sentence of each paragraph; stop and read properly when it matters.
5. **Write your four lines** (5 min). Below.

On the technical parts. Some readings have tables, regressions or formal models. You are not expected to follow the statistics this year. You *are* expected to work out what the author thinks they have shown, which is usually stated in words immediately before or after the table.

The four questions

Answer these for every reading, in writing. Four lines is enough.

1. **What is the question?** Not the topic — the question. “Nationalism” is a topic. “Why do some national movements turn violent and most do not?” is a question.
2. **What is the answer?** The argument, in one sentence, in your words.
3. **What is the evidence?** How many cases, which ones, what kind of data, over what period.
4. **Where is it weak?** What would have to be true for the argument to hold? Is there another explanation that fits the same evidence?

Question 4 is the one that separates a good tutorial contribution from a summary, and it is the one most people skip.

What your notes should look like

One short paragraph per reading, in your own words. Not highlighting — copying somebody else's sentences is not thinking, and you will not be able to use them in December.

Fearon, “What Is Identity?” Asks what social scientists actually mean by the word, and argues the everyday use hides two different things. Evidence is conceptual, not empirical — he works through how the term is used rather than testing anything. Weak point: if the concept is this slippery, it is not obvious what would count as evidence against him.

That is thirty seconds of work at the end of a reading, and it is the thing you revise from.

A worked example

McCombs & Shaw (1972), “The Agenda-Setting Function of Mass Media.” We use this in Lecture 3.

- **Question.** Does the news media shape what the public thinks is important?
- **Answer.** Largely yes — not by telling people what to think, but by telling them what to think *about*.
- **Evidence.** Undecided voters in Chapel Hill, North Carolina, during the 1968 US presidential campaign. They compared the issues those voters said mattered with the issues the local media covered most, and found the two lined up closely.
- **Weak point.** A correlation in one town, in one election, at one moment. It cannot show which way the causation runs: media may set the agenda, or may be covering what its audience already cares about.

That last bullet is the interesting one, and it is the kind of thing worth raising in a tutorial. The finding is famous; the design is a single snapshot. Holding both of those in your head at once is what reading political science actually is.

Noah: I picked McCombs & Shaw because it is already in lec03 and its limits are unusually teachable. Swap in whatever you would rather demonstrate on — the four bullets are the point, not the article.

Traps

- **Skimming the abstract and conclusion only.** It works right up until somebody asks you a question.
- **Reading for facts instead of for the argument.** You are not being tested on what happened in Hungary in 2011. You are being tested on what it shows.
- **Highlighting instead of writing.** A yellow page is not a note.
- **Assuming that because it is published, it is right.** Every reading on this list is arguable.

That is why it is on the list.

- **Leaving all four readings to the night before the tutorial.** Two done properly beats four skimmed, every time.

If you get stuck

Some readings this term are genuinely hard, and a few are hard on purpose. If you have given a reading a real attempt and it will not open up, bring that to your tutorial — “I could not follow section 3” is a perfectly good discussion point, and you will rarely be the only one.

The four questions are adapted from the reading guidance in my Russian Politics module, which in turn adapts Timothy Frye’s 2021 syllabus for “The Politics of Autocracy.”